

be gauged from the fact that US diplomats rushed to mediate between the two highest office-holders. Durrani himself admitted that Zardari called him after his removal to apologise for the manner in which it was done. For now, however, that is all that Zardari could do.

Durrani's sacking also brought into sharp relief a brewing tension between the military establishment and the civilian Government. Durrani—who also served as General Zia-ul-Haq's military secretary and remarkably escaped being on the C-130 that crashed taking Zia's life—has long been viewed with some distrust by certain sections of Pakistan's establishment. His long stints with various western think tanks after his

creasing involvement of Israel's Mossad in training Indian forces and the perception of "military encirclement" by India through a rising presence in Afghanistan, these fears—justifiable or not—are leading almost to a sense of paranoia. "America is losing the war in Afghanistan," one military source says, "and they need to find some way to divert attention away from it. Where do you think they will go?" Many within Pakistan believe that the troubles in Balochistan and the tribal agencies are being fomented by outside powers as a prelude to the dismemberment of the country and an attack on its nuclear weapons.

It is also in this context that the military has rebuffed attempts by Zardari and his Government to unilaterally redefine Pakistan's security doctrine and offer too many concessions to India. It is also, of course, attempting to preserve its turf. When General Ashfaq Parvez Kayani took over as army chief, US diplomats went out of their way to praise his leadership skills, his professionalism and to point out how comfortable they felt with him. As Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) chief under Musharraf, he had of course worked closely with his counterparts in the CIA. According to military sources, however, the Americans stopped sharing intelligence with Pakistan soon after, citing its leakage before critical attacks on wanted targets. The Predator-drone attacks on US targets intensified despite increasing political opposition to them within Pakistan. But the army was more upset that the American drones never hit the targets important to them. In one instance, militants being hunted by the Pakistan Army, who had hijacked two US Humvees, roamed around for days in the vehicles without being hit.

At the same time, Pakistan's army faces increasing US pressure to transform itself from a military force focused on India into a counter-insurgency force, a demand many within the military feel uncomfortable with. Interestingly, soon after the Mumbai terror attacks and the attacks on NATO supply routes, the US is once again beginning to share intelligence with Pakistan. The US also realises the dangers in alienating the powerful military completely, not least of all to its war in Afghanistan. While some within the US have advocated "calling Pakistan's bluff"—a reference to Pakistan's threats of abandoning the western front over rising tensions with India—the negative fallout of such a strategy going wrong are substantial. For President Zardari and the nascent PPP Government, the hope is in simply riding out this push and pull. For India, though, the internal divisions only highlight the dilemma of dealing with Pakistan post the Mumbai attacks. ■



KAYANI (L)
AND DURRANI

retirement and his sudden appointment, first as Pakistan's ambassador in Washington under Musharraf, and subsequently as NSA by Zardari, have led to eyebrows being raised. Sources indicate that there is also a quiet distrust within the military establishment of certain key figures in the elected Government who are considered "compromised" and " beholden" to western powers. Some say Durrani's sacking may have had the tacit approval of the military.

The tensions between India and Pakistan over the Mumbai attacks may occupy centrestage in the media on both sides of the border. But there is a "much bigger game with greater stakes" playing out, in the words of a political insider. "This has to do with settling the rules of engagement between Pakistan and the Americans." Pakistan's security establishment is extremely apprehensive about US designs in the region, an uneasiness that is being fed by the rising calls within the US to expand its theatre of operations in Afghanistan to include Pakistan's tribal areas, as well as the stream of western media speculation about the "safety" of Pakistan's nuclear weapons. Coupled with a perceived American tilt towards India, the in-